



P51 · 30 PAGES, PRINTABLE + FILLABLE

The Pregnancy Safety Reference

A thirty-page reference for the everyday "is this okay" questions of pregnancy. Organized by category, food, drink, activity, environment, medication classes, workplace, travel, so the parent can write down what they want to ask the provider in one conversation instead of ten 2am Google searches. The reference does NOT make safety verdicts. It organizes the questions. The answers belong to the provider.

Soothemade Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A PLANNING AND TRACKING TOOL · NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

A note before you start

Pregnancy is a long stretch of small questions.

Most are five-second conversations with a provider. But the questions don't arrive when the provider is in the room. They arrive at 11pm on a Tuesday, when the answer you have is Google, which has six different verdicts on every topic.

This reference is the bridge. It organizes the categories of questions pregnant people commonly have, so you can carry them to your provider as a list, in one conversation. It is the question surface.

It does not answer your questions. It does not say "this is safe" or "this is dangerous." Your specific pregnancy, your specific health history, your specific risk factors, all of those belong to a real human provider who knows them. The reference is the prep work for the conversation.

Soothemade

This is a question-organization reference, not medical advice. For specific safety questions about your pregnancy, please follow your obstetric provider's guidance. This reference does NOT name medications. It does NOT make safety verdicts. It does NOT specify thresholds. The reference is the list. The answers belong to your provider.

How to use this reference

- Read through once, just to see what categories exist.
- As questions come up, mark the relevant page.
- At your next appointment, bring the questions you've collected.
- Write down what your provider said next to each one.
- For follow-up questions, call the provider's nurse line. Do not let the internet be the tiebreaker.

A small principle: the internet's biggest weakness in pregnancy advice is that it cannot see YOU. It cannot see your medical history, your specific pregnancy, your particular risk factors. Your provider can. The reference is here to get you to the provider faster.

The big disclaimer (read this once)

This reference does not give verdicts. Here is why.

Pregnancy safety is individual. "Is X safe in pregnancy" almost always has a more accurate answer than yes or no. The more accurate answer is "for whom, at what amount, at what stage, with what other factors." That sentence is a provider's sentence, not a reference book's.

The science updates. What was considered safe in one decade is sometimes revised. The current best advice for your country, your year, and your situation comes from a clinician who follows the current guidelines.

Risk tolerance varies. Some pregnant people want to be extra cautious. Some are okay with a wider margin. Both are reasonable. The right margin is the one you decide with your provider.

The reference's only job: to get you to the conversation. Once you're in the conversation, you and the provider decide together.

WHAT I AM NOT DOING WITH THIS REFERENCE

- ☐ Trying to be safer than my provider thinks I need to be
- ☐ Trying to "win" against forum posts
- ☐ Trying to find absolute safety (it does not exist)
- ☐ Trying to second-guess my provider

WHAT I AM DOING

- ☐ Collecting questions in one place
- ☐ Bringing them to my next appointment
- ☐ Trusting the provider's interpretation
- ☐ Letting go of the rest

Food: the questions most people have

The common categories. Not a verdict list.

DELI AND PRE-MADE MEATS

Questions to bring up:

- Cold cuts at the store
- Hot dogs, sausages
- Pre-packaged deli sandwiches
- Meat trays at parties

SOFT AND UNPASTEURIZED CHEESES

Questions:

- Brie, camembert, blue cheese, feta
- Queso fresco, queso blanco
- Anything "raw milk" or "unpasteurized"

UNDERCOOKED OR RAW PROTEIN

Questions:

- Sushi (raw fish vs cooked)
- Steak temperature
- Runny eggs (poached, soft-boiled, over easy)
- Cookie dough
- Caesar dressing (if raw egg)
- Tartare, carpaccio, ceviche

FISH SPECIFICALLY

Questions:

- High-mercury vs low-mercury
- How much per week (your provider has the latest guidance)
- Smoked fish (lox, smoked salmon)
- Canned tuna

UNPASTEURIZED DAIRY AND JUICE

Questions:

- Raw-milk products
- Fresh-squeezed juice from a place that does not pasteurize
- Farmer's market dairy

FOOD HANDLING + LEFTOVERS

Questions:

- How long can leftovers safely be kept
- Reheating from frozen
- Restaurant takeout left in the car
- Buffets and salad bars

CAFFEINE

Questions:

- Coffee daily limit
- Caffeinated tea
- Energy drinks, sodas
- Caffeine in chocolate

SUGAR SUBSTITUTES

Questions:

- Common artificial sweeteners
- Stevia
- Sugar alcohols

CULTURAL OR REGIONAL FOODS

Questions:

- Foods specific to your background that are not in standard guidance lists
- Traditional or family recipes you grew up with

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT FOOD

Drinks

ALCOHOL

The general guidance in most countries is zero alcohol during pregnancy. Your provider will be specific to you. If you drank before you knew you were pregnant, that is also a conversation to have.

Questions:

- Cooking with alcohol (cooks off vs not)
- Communion wine
- Non-alcoholic beer + wine

CAFFEINE

See food page.

HERBAL TEAS

Questions:

- Common herbal teas (some are considered fine, some not, your provider will know which)
- Pregnancy-marketed teas (e.g. raspberry leaf)
- Detox teas
- Kombucha

HYDRATION GENERALLY

Questions:

- How much water per day in pregnancy
- Electrolyte drinks (sports drinks)
- Coconut water

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT DRINKS

Activities

EXERCISE

Questions:

- Continuing my current exercise routine
- Running while pregnant
- Weight lifting
- High-intensity classes
- Pregnancy-modified options
- Heart-rate caps (most current guidance has moved away from a specific number, but ask your provider)

SEX

Questions:

- When sex is and is not a question
- Position considerations later in pregnancy
- If I have been told to avoid it (placenta previa, bleeding, etc.)

SPORTS

Questions:

- Contact sports
- Sports with fall risk (skiing, horseback riding, biking)
- Water sports
- Scuba diving (most guidance says no during pregnancy, ask)

HOT ACTIVITIES

Questions:

- Hot tubs, saunas, steam rooms
- Hot yoga / Bikram
- Hot baths (how hot is too hot)
- Heated workouts

LOW-IMPACT

Questions:

- Walking guidance
- Prenatal yoga
- Swimming
- Pilates

HOBBIES

Questions:

- Crafts with chemicals (resin, certain paints, soldering)

- Heavy gardening
- Pottery (some glazes contain materials worth discussing)

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT ACTIVITY

Environment

HOUSEHOLD CHEMICALS

Questions:

- Bleach and cleaning products
- Bug sprays
- Pesticides in the yard
- Drain cleaners

PAINT + RENOVATION

Questions:

- Painting the nursery
- Sanding old (possibly lead) paint
- Wallpaper removal
- Asbestos (very old houses)
- Off-gassing from new furniture, mattresses, flooring

PETS

Questions:

- Cat litter (toxoplasmosis is a known consideration)
- Cleaning pet waste
- Pet medications you handle
- Bringing a new pet home during pregnancy

SALONS + PERSONAL CARE

Questions:

- Hair dye + bleach
- Nail salons (acrylics, gel, the chemical exposure)
- Spray tans
- Botox and other cosmetic procedures
- Whitening teeth
- Acne medications (route to provider, name not in this reference)

ELECTRONICS + RADIATION

Questions:

- Microwaves
- Cell phones
- Airport security scanners
- Dental x-rays
- Medical imaging (your provider will weigh)

HEAT EXPOSURE

Questions:

- Heating pads (most are okay, ask)
- Electric blankets
- Hot car / hot day exposure

OUTDOOR ENVIRONMENT

Questions:

- Air quality + wildfire smoke
- High altitude
- Sun exposure + sunscreen

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT ENVIRONMENT

Medications by class

The reference does NOT name medications. Your provider does, and your pharmacist confirms. The categories are listed by purpose so you can identify what to bring to the conversation.

PAIN AND FEVER

"I have a headache" or "I have a fever", your provider has a specific recommendation. Do not assume what you took before is the same recommendation now.

What to bring to the provider:

- The specific symptom
- How often it happens
- What you have been taking, if anything
- The dose and frequency

ALLERGIES

"I have seasonal allergies." Some options are routinely okayed in pregnancy, some are not. Ask before refilling your usual prescription.

COLD AND FLU

Multi-symptom cold medications often contain multiple ingredients, some of which are not first-line in pregnancy. Ask your provider for a recommendation BEFORE getting sick if possible. Get the flu shot conversation with your provider (a separate topic).

GASTROINTESTINAL

Heartburn, constipation, diarrhea, nausea. Each has a different provider-recommendation conversation.

MENTAL HEALTH

If you take medication for depression, anxiety, ADHD, bipolar disorder, or any other mental-health condition, this is a conversation to have with both your prescriber AND your OB, ideally BEFORE pregnancy starts. The risk of untreated illness is not zero. The risk of any particular medication is also not zero. The two-doctor conversation balances them.

CHRONIC CONDITIONS

Asthma, diabetes, thyroid, high blood pressure, autoimmune conditions. Pregnancy changes how each is managed. Coordinate with both your specialist and your OB.

VITAMINS + SUPPLEMENTS

Prenatal vitamins are standard. Folate / folic acid is standard. Beyond that, every supplement deserves a conversation. Some are recommended (D, omega-3 in some cases, iron when low). Some are not (high-dose A is a known issue, certain herbs). Your provider has the current guidance.

EVERYTHING ELSE

Sleep aids, antibiotics if you get an infection, antifungals, numbing creams, anything you put on your skin, anything you put in your mouth, all of these are conversations.

A NOTE: NEVER ASSUME THE OVER-THE-COUNTER MEDICATION YOU TOOK BEFORE PREGNANCY IS THE RIGHT CHOICE NOW. THE SHELF AT THE PHARMACY IS NOT A PREGNANCY-VETTED SHELF. ASK BEFORE TAKING.

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT MEDICATIONS

Workplace

PHYSICAL DEMANDS

Questions:

- Lifting limits (your provider has specifics for you)
- Long stretches of standing
- Long stretches of sitting
- Climbing ladders or stairs at work
- Night shifts and rotating shifts

ENVIRONMENTAL EXPOSURES AT WORK

Questions:

- Chemicals you work with (chemists, lab workers, hairdressers, nail techs, agricultural workers, manufacturing)
- Radiation (medical workers, certain manufacturing)
- Heat exposure (kitchens, foundries, outdoor in summer)
- Biological hazards (healthcare, childcare, veterinary)
- Vibration and prolonged sitting (drivers, pilots)

ACCOMMODATIONS

Most places have a process for pregnancy-related workplace accommodations. The Pregnancy Workers Fairness Act in the US (and similar laws elsewhere) makes reasonable accommodations broadly available.

What to ask:

- Modified duties
- Extra breaks
- Sitting where you used to stand
- A different shift
- A reassignment from a specific exposure
- Time off for appointments

A NOTE: A LETTER FROM YOUR PROVIDER OFTEN HELPS GET ACCOMMODATIONS APPROVED. ASK FOR ONE.

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT WORK

(See P54 Pregnancy + Work Planner for the deeper conversation templates with HR, your manager, and the leave-planning details.)

Travel

AIR TRAVEL

Questions:

- Until what week
- Most airlines have policies (often 36 weeks domestic, earlier internationally)
- Compression socks
- Hydration
- Aisle vs window
- Letter from provider (some airlines require this past 28 weeks)

CAR TRAVEL

Questions:

- Long road trips (frequent stops to walk)
- Seatbelt positioning over the bump
- Driving comfortably later in pregnancy

CRUISE

Questions:

- Cruise lines have policies (often won't board past 24 weeks)
- On-board medical care

INTERNATIONAL

Questions:

- Vaccinations needed for the destination (some are not recommended in pregnancy)
- Zika and other disease considerations for the destination
- Healthcare access at destination
- Travel insurance with pregnancy coverage
- Letter from provider

ALTITUDE

Questions:

- High-altitude destinations
- Sudden altitude changes

WHAT I WANT TO ASK MY PROVIDER ABOUT TRAVEL

“What they say but actually” overview

This page is for the kind of question that has a one-line internet answer that is misleading. The reference says: ask your provider, but here are the typical reasons people get confused.

"NEVER X" IN PREGNANCY

When you see "never X" in pregnancy advice, it usually means: the RISK is non-zero and the BENEFIT is low. For most "never X" rules, asking your provider can clarify whether your specific risk is meaningful or not.

"X IS FINE" IN PREGNANCY

When you see "X is fine," it usually means: the risk is low at normal amounts. "Normal amounts" varies by person. Ask your provider what normal means for you.

"I HEARD ON A PODCAST..."

Podcasts and influencer accounts are not your provider. They are sometimes accurate, sometimes not. They are usually generic. Your provider knows your specifics.

"SOMEONE ON A FORUM SAID..."

Forum posts are anecdotes. Your provider has evidence.

"MY OWN MOTHER DID X IN HER PREGNANCY AND I WAS FINE"

Pregnancy guidance has changed in many areas. Your mother's pregnancy in 1985 followed different recommendations. Ask what's current.

"MY FRIEND'S DOCTOR SAID Y"

Friend's doctor may be right for your friend. Your friend's pregnancy is not yours.

THE PATTERN

Whenever you encounter a strong claim about pregnancy safety online, write it down. Bring it to your provider. They will tell you whether it applies to you or not.

“If I already did this thing” page

The internet often makes pregnant people feel like every past action is a catastrophe. It usually isn't. This page is the calm framework for the past-tense question.

THE CALM FRAMEWORK

You did the thing. Maybe before you knew you were pregnant. Maybe because the internet was wrong. Maybe because life was happening.

Here is what to do.

1. Write down what happened, with details.

What I did:

How much:

When (week of pregnancy):

Anything else relevant:

2. Mention it at your next appointment, or call the nurse line if it feels urgent.
3. Do NOT spiral on the internet between now and the appointment.
4. Trust your provider's interpretation.

A REMINDER: PREGNANCY IS RESILIENT. THE BABY IS PROTECTED BY MANY LAYERS. A SINGLE EXPOSURE OR ACCIDENT OR FORGOTTEN DOSE IS RARELY THE DISASTER THE INTERNET WILL SUGGEST. PROVIDERS HAVE SEEN ALL OF IT. THE PROVIDER IS THE RIGHT JUDGE OF YOUR SITUATION.

THE OPPOSITE IS ALSO TRUE: IF YOU GENUINELY ARE WORRIED ABOUT A SPECIFIC EXPOSURE OR EVENT, CALL THE PROVIDER. THE NURSE LINE IS THERE FOR THIS. CALLING DOES NOT MAKE YOU NEUROTIC. IT MAKES YOU INFORMED.

Question-list template for your provider

The point of this whole reference. Bring this filled-in page to your appointment.

APPOINTMENT DATE: _____

TOP QUESTIONS (the ones I most want answered)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

FOOD AND DRINK QUESTIONS

ACTIVITY QUESTIONS

ENVIRONMENT QUESTIONS

MEDICATION QUESTIONS (bring the symptom + what you have been considering, NOT the medication name itself)

WORK QUESTIONS

TRAVEL QUESTIONS

ANYTHING THAT HAPPENED THAT I AM WORRIED ABOUT

WHAT THEY TOLD ME (fill in after)

WHAT THEY WANT ME TO DO BEFORE THE NEXT VISIT

A final note

You will have a hundred questions in this pregnancy. Some will be small. Some will keep you up.

The reference is the bridge. The provider is the answer. The two together make pregnancy meaningfully less anxious than the internet alone.

When you find yourself googling something at 11pm, write it down here instead. By Tuesday's appointment, you have a list. By the appointment after, you have answers.

You are not being difficult by asking. You are being a good advocate for the pregnancy. Good providers want patients who ask.

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Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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